

PREGNANCY

Having baby during pandemic 'uncharted territory' for all

Parents, doctors, hospitals reevaluate protocols, deliveries.

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For Devina Lalla, expecting a baby in the midst of a coronavirus pandemic raises new challenges and questions, and sparks waves of anxiety. It also had Lalla considering what would otherwise be unthinkable for her — a home birth.

Lalla quickly dropped the idea after learning rubbing alcohol, considered an essential for delivery at home, is on back order for months.

"Being pregnant for the first time can be stressful anyway," said Lalla of east Cobb County, who is due July 4. "But this is uncharted territory for what it means for moms and their babies."

Pregnant women, along with their partners, are on high alert and hunkering down at home to reduce the risk of possible exposure to the highly contagious coronavirus. They are forced to come to terms with difficult circumstances surrounding their pregnancies, such as skipping some appointments or doing them via video chat.

Metro Atlanta hospitals, including Northside, Piedmont and Emory, are severely restricting visitors and allowing women in labor and delivery to have only one support person accompany them. If they bring their spouse, they cannot bring anyone else, including their doula. And more restrictions may be on the way as the new coronavirus quickly spreads, now surpassing 2,000 confirmed cases in the state.

All the while, it's not known how the coronavirus affects pregnancy. The American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists says "very little is known" about COVID-19 — the disease caused by the coronavirus — and its effect on pregnant women and infants.

While most people with COVID-19 suffer mild to moderate symptoms, adults over 60 and those



Devina Lalla and husband Jared Putman are expecting their first child this summer. They briefly considered a home birth.



Elizabeth and Scott Meachum are expecting twin boys in late April and have been trying video chats with their doula.



Shweta and Yatin Kanetkar are parents to Arya, 3, and are expecting a boy in August. "I'm trying not to psych myself out too much by keeping up to date with major headlines but not reading about the coronavirus too much," Shweta said. CONTRIBUTED PHOTOS

several measures are in place at OB-GYN clinics and hospitals to help reduce the spread of the coronavirus. Patients in labor are evaluated and admitted to special rooms.

He said suspected COVID-19 patients are evaluated in an isolated area in the emergency department and admitted only to designated floors.

He said many OB-GYN offices are discouraging non-urgent

suspected coronavirus.

Northside and other hospitals have also recently stopped allowing visitors, including parents, to visit newborns in neonatal intensive care units to prevent the transmission of COVID-19. Many of the hospitals, including Northside, are giving parents iPads to connect to their babies through video interactions.

Grogan encourages pregnant women worried about giving

of a not-so-great situation," she said. "I would hate to be the person asymptomatic and be spreading it to a client and not finding about it until later or that anyone in the hospital could be exposed because of me. In the end, it's more important to keep you and me safe and healthy than risk exposure."

Douglas, who has been a doula for more than 100 women and their partners, said she will compensate for what is lost through virtual support.

"As humans, we have five senses, and when one is taken away, the others are heightened," Douglas said. "If I am not there personally, I will beef up emotional support and communicate very effectively."

Douglas has started doing trial runs using video chat with her clients, including Scott and Elizabeth Meachum, who is pregnant with twins and due in late April.

Shweta Kanetkar, a research scientist at Georgia Tech and due with her second child, a boy, in early August, said she's trying to stick to a routine and stay positive. The Smyrna woman enjoys spending more time with her 3-year-old daughter, Arya. She's also started daily meditation.

"We are taking each day as it comes," she said, "and I'm trying not to psych myself out too much by keeping up to date with major headlines but not reading about the coronavirus too much."

Kanetkar, who is 35, said she's noticed her husband, Yatin Kanetkar, is more protective. He does all the grocery shopping and wipes down everything, including cans, in the garage first before bringing anything inside the house.

Meanwhile, Lalla, who is 32 and is a professor at Savannah College of Art and Design, said preparing for the birth of her first child during a public health crisis has forced her and her husband to focus on what really matters. That means dropping plans to leave the house to shop for curtains, plants and baby-friendly artwork, and getting the nursery ready.

"I would have been freaking out about not having a nursery

3 THINGS SMOKERS SHOULD KNOW ABOUT COVID-19

Everyone is at risk of contracting the coronavirus that causes COVID-19.

The illness is particularly dangerous for people with underlying conditions, such as heart or lung disease. Dr. Neal Patel, a Mayo Clinic pulmonologist and critical care medicine specialist, says people who smoke tobacco products, e-cigarettes or marijuana also may be at increased risk of becoming very sick if they contract the virus.

"Smoking makes you more susceptible to COVID-19, because it destroys some of your lungs' natural defense mechanisms," says Dr. Patel. "Vaping may do the same thing."

A recent blog published by the National Institutes of Health explains that initial reviews of COVID-19 cases in China show smokers may have developed more severe disease than nonsmokers. More research is needed to determine what effect smoking or vaping has on people with COVID-19, but Dr. Patel says people should do whatever they can to quit now.



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